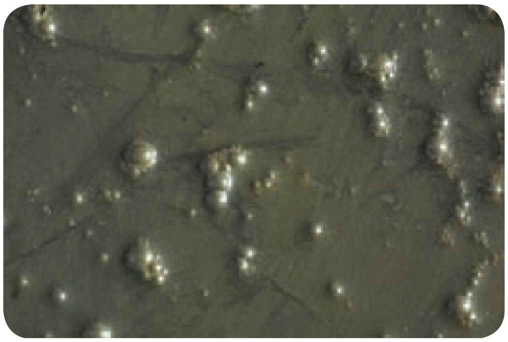
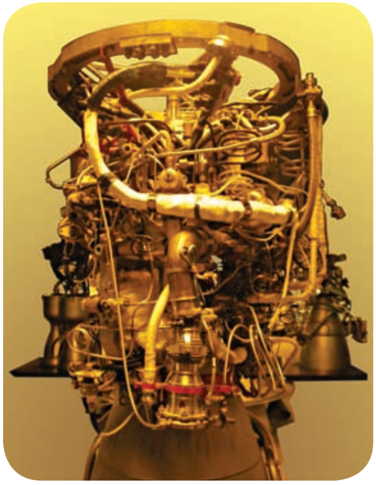


me staggeringly well, must have been made to have me in it!" The key here is the fact that even a puddle of protoplasm can be sentient elsewhere because of the way it evolved to fit that world. Aware, but would it be intelligent? Perhaps. Imagine walking around on an alien planet and stepping into some goop and it shouts back at you "hey watch it, you just stepped on my crotch there!".

Such life may have evolved in such a way that it doesn't need visual perceptory mechanisms we call eyes. Even the inventions of such life and their civilisation may be biological and not like the machines we've created.

CHILDREN OF CONVERGENT EVOLUTION

Most of our fiction-makers conjure up aliens (even the wildly imaginative ones) as anthropomorphic (or ascribing human form). They have a face, legs, arms and maybe even genitalia. We emphasise the last bit as Trekkies would be familiar with half-human hybrids all over the Star Trek universe. All these unholy unions were even plausible to an intelligent viewer because of the anthropomorphic form that most aliens strangely adhered to. So what is it about the hominid form that we like so much or perhaps nature likes so much? The answer lies in the theory of convergent evolution which states that species evolve and develop similar solutions to adapt to certain environmental challenges. The perfect example of convergent evolution is the number of aquatic organisms from different lineages – from fish to dolphins – that developed the teardrop shape for optimal efficiency. The shape makes them streamlined and hence faster to catch prey and escape too. In the same way, scientists postulate that the human form is perhaps the epitome of evolutionary advancement; after all, we're the dominant species. Those large brains, industrious thumbs, stereo vision and long limbs all worked to our advantage over the eons. This makes scientists assume that creatures on other worlds would also share the same characteristics and be much like us. Quite frankly, it sounds like we're vain enough to believe that we're the best way to be. What we don't consider is that alien worlds may not be like ours. Creatures on other worlds may require other evolutionary changes and adaptations. Who knows, maybe on a world where there are high surface pressures a triangular shape may be the perfect way to be. Imagine a bunch of pyramids walking around eating square-shaped hot dogs.



DUES EX MACHINA

The most plausible theory of all though is that we may not meet people at all. Who will we meet then? In all likelihood their creations. The evidence for this lies in the history of our own civilisation. We discovered electricity and radio in the late 1800s and within a span of a hundred years we have computers. This is quite a telescopic progression. Extrapolating on this level of advancement, the next step which is thinking machines, is barely another hundred years away. We would then have, in a way, given birth to our successors.

In our last Space Age feature, we looked at how mankind would explore the final frontier. And considering all the hazards of space, we concluded that it would have to be done by proxy through machines. The same would be the case with any technologically advanced civilisation. So, instead of biotic organisms our first encounter might just be with an advanced thinking machine. While hominid Robots are a familiar and perhaps comforting thought, a sentient machine's design will be as per its function. And if a cube is the perfect form, you can forget about meeting Optimus Prime or any of the Autobots.

STEPHEN HAWKING SPEAKS

The respected theoretical physicist has been quite vocal about aliens. He warns that Alien technology may make ours look like the dark ages... Watch the video: http://bit.ly/space06

EVERYONE WAS A STAR

The next time you see yourself in the mirror, remember that you were a part of a star before the star exploded into a supernova. The hydrogen in stars combine to form helium which in turn combines to form heavier elements. http://bit.ly/space05

ALIEN LIFE ON EARTH?

NASA's Dr. Richard B. Hoover, in the Journal of Cosmology, claims to have found alien life in the form of bacteria on a meteorite named CI1 carbonaceous Chondrites. Only nine such meteorites are known to exist on Earth. http://bit.ly/space07

MOST REALISTIC ALIENS

It's been widely accepted that much of the life that we'll come across in space would be of the microbial kind. In our solar system itself there are likely hotbeds such as Ganymede, Europa and IO which could be rich in mico-organisms of all kinds. Perhaps our Moon too.